In his remarks on the way forward, the prime minister proposed the creation of a COVID-19 emergency fund based on voluntary contributions. He added that India would begin by offering $10 billion and that any of the member nations could utilize the fund in their fight against the virus.

He also added that India would assemble a rapid response team of doctors and specialists equipped with testing kits and other essential items which will be on standby to be placed at the disposal on any nation's requirement. He further stated that India can provide online training for emergency response teams of member nations based on the model we have used to raise the capacity of our emergency personnel. He further informed that India has set up an integrated disease surveillance portal to better trace possible virus carriers and their contacts which we would be happy to share along with training on how to use it. He insisted that the SAARC Disaster Management Centre must collate the best practices among all of us and set up a common platform for research on controlling epidemics in the South Asian region. He added that the ICMR can help to coordinate this exercise. As a parting note, Modi mentioned that India will ask its experts to brainstorm on longer economic consequences of COVID-19 and how we can insulate our internal trade and local value chains from its impact.[12]

In his concluding remarks, the prime minister expressed his desire to work on strengthening cooperation between the SAARC nations to together fight the pandemic and share knowledge-based practices, capacities and resources wherever possible.[13]

Even before the announcement for a SAARC video conference, the prime minister, on 12 March, had spoken with the British prime minister, Boris Johnson and Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu on the evolving COVID-19 crisis and the response mechanisms of both countries. In the spirit of collaboration, on 17 March, he had a conversation with the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia Mohammed bin Salman on what both countries were undertaking in their fight against the virus.

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18 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 152 ACTIVE CASES | 3 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,92,164 ACTIVE CASES | 9,070 DEATHS